

ON THE BOIL

- **May 9:** RPG attack on intelligence headquarters of Punjab police in Mohali, SFJ claims credit
- **April 29:** Clash between Hindutva outfits and Sikh radical outfits at anti-Khalistan rally in Patiala
- **December 23, 2021:** Bomb blast at Ludhiana court
- **November 7, 2021:** Grenade attack on Nawanshahr police station

was to execute serial blasts in Mumbai. The police are yet to ascertain the exact destination for the seized explosives. Rinda apparently used to send them locations on an app, guiding them on where and when to make deliveries, Karnal SP Ganga Ram Punia told INDIA TODAY.

Born in Tarn Taran district, Rinda grew up in Nanded before coming back to attend Panjab University in 2015. But he continued to run his gang there while extending his operations to Punjab. A proclaimed offender (PO), the Nanded police have charged him in two murder cases along with cases of extortion going as far back as February 2016.

Author and commentator Jagtar Sandhu says this is a new trend seen in the past few years where Khalistani groups have started using criminals and gangsters, and not ideologically committed people, to get their work done. Jagdish Mittal says most of those involved in terror incidents are not even Sikhs. They are from poor families, mostly unemployed and were promised money or a future abroad.

Top officials at the Indian security agencies say the Pakistani intelligence service ISI has floated a new platform, the Lashkar-e-Khalsa, with Pakistan-based Khalistani outfits to train and provide logistics to these criminal elements. The Indian agencies believe Taliban mercenaries too are part of the group to provide weapons training. Incidentally, the Mohali attack on the Intelligence HQ used a Chinese-made RPG. The weapon has been a favourite of the Taliban in Afghanistan and Syrian rebels. In India, Naxal outfits in Chhattisgarh are said to have access to it, but this is a first for Khalistani outfits. In January this year, the Gurdaspur police had recovered an under-barrel grenade launcher (UBGL) from the Dinanagar area of the city. It was apparently air-dropped using drones by Rode. Indian officials say the ISI has been helping these outfits in using drones since 2019 to offload weapons and drugs in the border districts of Punjab and J&K. Then chief minister Amarinder Singh had prepared a dossier linking the air-dropping of weapons and drugs with Khalistani terror outfits, but nothing much came of it.

Keeping the pot of Khalistani sentiment boiling does help the outfits sitting in Pakistan, UK, USA, EU, Australia and Canada. The movement's second avatar now has a far more influential Sikh diaspora extending it logistical support. Organisations like the SFJ and the Canada-based Poetic Justice Foundation are part of a conventional Khalistan network whose propaganda is carried out through the gurdwaras in their countries.

The protests against the contentious farm laws became one more excuse to whip up anti-government sentiments among the Sikh diaspora. Security agencies are now carefully analysing the tweets and statements of Sikh politicians in UK and Canada. In mid-April, the BJP had criticised Mann for hosting British Labour MP Tanmanjeet Singh Dhesi, who routinely amplifies rights violations by Indian security agencies in Kashmir. In December 2020, at a protest Dhesi organised in London opposite the Indian High Commission, pro-Khalistan slogans too were raised. The attendees included Khalistan Tiger Force's Paramjit Pamma. Dhesi, however, denies any links to Khalistani outfits. In the past, Mann's predecessors like Parkash Singh Badal and Amarinder remained extra cautious while meeting controversial Sikh politicians from the West. In fact, Amarinder had refused to meet Canadian minister Harjit Singh Sajjan in 2017 saying his family had links with pro-Khalistan outfits.

Meanwhile, Jagtar Sandhu believes the Khalistan movement may have died but the idea has not. The weapons seizures, scattered violence and recalcitrant elements raising the Khalistan issue at public forums are all incidents in continuity. "It's a cat-and-mouse game. The government of the day will have to crack down while these elements will continue with their bench job." For now, he says, it's a law and order problem but a solution will have to be political. Meanwhile, the police in Punjab are embarrassed with the attack on their intelligence HQ and the citizens anxious. Mann is assuring action, but mere words won't suffice this time. ■